What is Truth?
A Humble Inquiry

Pearl Bipin Pulickal

Introduction

Pontius Pilate once asked Jesus, "What is truth?" This ancient question continues to challenge philosophers, scientists, and everyday seekers alike. What follows is a humble, respectful, and firm attempt to offer a grounded theory of truth—a framework that does not presume to possess all the answers, nor to solve the mystery once and for all. Rather, it seeks to offer a coherent, rational structure that honors truth without arrogance and defends reason without dismissing humility.

Part I: The Search Begins — What Is Truth?

Truth, at its core, is that which corresponds to reality. [1] This echoes what is often called the Correspondence Theory of Truth—that a claim is true if it matches the way the world actually is.

But how do we know what reality is? If one person says, "1 + 1 = 2," and another insists, "1 + 1 = 3," whom should we believe—and why?

The first test is logical coherence. In mathematics, we operate within a formal system of axioms and rules. Within that system, "1 + 1 = 2" is not a matter of opinion—it is a theorem. It follows from a chain of proofs. It has internal consistency, and it's also testable: if I place one apple next to another, I count two.

But what if someone says, "You're hallucinating," or "You're being gaslit," or simply, "You're wrong"? This challenge moves us to deeper layers of justification.

[1] Aristotle. *Metaphysics*, Book IV, Part 7.

Part II: The Layers of Confidence

To responsibly believe a claim is true, we must climb a set of epistemic layers—levels of confidence that fortify our belief. [2] Each layer offers a different form of justification. The more a claim satisfies, the more rational we are to trust it.

- **Logical and Mathematical Foundation** — Does the claim follow from accepted principles of reasoning? Is it internally coherent?
- **Sensory Observation** — Can it be perceived through our senses, under normal conditions?
- **Reproducibility** — Can the observation or outcome be independently repeated by others?
- **Peer Review and Testimony** — Is there reliable, consistent, and cross-verifiable testimony from credible sources?
- **Time and Resilience** — Has the claim withstood critical scrutiny over time?

These five layers do not guarantee infallibility—but they form a rational scaffold for responsible belief. If someone claims that 1 + 1 = 3, they must present evidence that overturns all five layers. In the absence of such evidence, we are justified—without arrogance—in affirming 1 + 1 = 2.

Part III: The Problem of Precision and Context

Truth is not diminished by contextual expression. Take the claim, "The Earth is a sphere." Technically, the Earth is an oblate spheroid, slightly flattened at the poles. [3] So, were we wrong to call it a sphere? Not at all.

Truth, when expressed, is shaped by context. For a classroom globe, "sphere" is appropriate. For orbital physics, more precision is necessary.

The core insight is this: truth is not relative, but language is limited. Our descriptions must match our purpose. Imperfect expression does not equal falsehood. Truth is context-sensitive in articulation, not in nature.

[2] Audi, R. (2010). *Epistemology: A Contemporary Introduction to the Theory of Knowledge* (3rd ed.). Routledge.

[3] Vaníček, P., & Krakiwsky, E. J. (1986). *Geodesy: The Concepts*. Elsevier.

Part IV: The Quantum Analogy — Unknown Truths

Before a claim is confirmed or denied, it exists in what we might call an epistemic quantum state—not because reality is undecided, but because our access to it is.

If I haven't seen my friend in months, is he alive or dead? The truth exists, but I do not yet know it. In that gap lies epistemic humility—the honest recognition that there is a difference between what is and what we know. [4]

This humility does not weaken the pursuit of truth—it strengthens it. The unknown is not unknowable. It is simply not yet known.

Part V: Weighted Occam's Razor

When confronted with competing explanations, we turn to Occam's Razor—the principle that, all things equal, the simplest explanation is preferred. [5]

But simplicity alone can mislead. So we apply a more careful tool: **Weighted Occam's Razor**. This means choosing the explanation that is:

- As simple as possible,
- As complex as necessary,
- And most proportional to the evidence.

If one theory says, "The moon is a sticker in the sky," and another says, "The moon is a rocky satellite reflecting sunlight," we don't choose the one with fewer syllables. We choose the one that better fits:

- Observational data,
- Physical models,
- Reproducible findings.

Truth is not always the simplest explanation—but it is the best-fitted one.

[4] Husserl, E. (1913). *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology*.

[5] Thorburn, W. M. (1915). The Myth of Occam's Razor. *Mind*, 24(96), 345–353.

Part VI: The Limitations of the Theory

This theory does not—and cannot—guarantee certainty in all things. It offers a framework, not a final answer.

It cannot resolve subjective truths—such as beauty, love, or justice. These require additional lenses: aesthetic, moral, spiritual.

It presumes a rational mind and a reasonably stable reality—assumptions that are deeply intuitive, though not infallibly provable.

It does not eliminate doubt—but it gives us tools to navigate it responsibly.

To accept these limits is not defeat; it is intellectual honesty.

Part VII: The Pragmatic Stop — Avoiding the Rabbit Hole of Over-Analysis

The very tools of this theory—the layers of confidence, the demand for precision, the weighted razor—can be turned against its purpose. A seeker of truth can become a purveyor of endless skepticism, entering a rabbit hole of over-analysis where the demand for justification becomes so absolute that no claim can ever be responsibly accepted. This is not rigor; it is a fortress of doubt disguised as intellectual integrity.

To guard against this, we must introduce a final principle: **The Pragmatic Stop**. The Pragmatic Stop is the recognition that the goal of this framework is not infallible certainty, but responsible and functional belief. It is a commitment to keeping the analysis proportional to the claim.

It can be stated as follows:

> The pursuit of justification should proceed only as far as it is meaningful for the context. When analysis ceases to provide greater clarity about reality and instead begins to serve itself—generating increasingly trivial or purely abstract objections—it is time to stop.

Consider again the claim, "The Earth is a sphere." We clarified this is a contextual truth, with "oblate spheroid" being more precise. A person falling into the rabbit hole would not stop there. They would argue:

- "But the Earth is not a perfect oblate spheroid due to mountains and trenches."
- "But its mass is not uniformly distributed."

- ″But what do you mean by ′Earth′? Are you including its atmosphere?″
- ″What is ′is′? How can we be certain of existence?″

At this point, the inquiry is no longer serving a meaningful purpose. It has become a performance of skepticism. The Pragmatic Stop commands us to ask: ″Does this next layer of analysis help me build a better model of reality, or is it simply a tool to avoid committing to any model at all?″

Truth-seeking requires a gas pedal (the pursuit of evidence) and a brake (the wisdom to know when a conclusion is warranted for a given purpose). The Pragmatic Stop is that brake. It is the final piece of humility: the wisdom to accept a well-justified belief and act upon it, rather than demanding a perfection of knowledge that humans can never attain.

Conclusion

This theory of truth does not claim to be ultimate. It claims only to be grounded—in reason, observation, coherence, and humility.

It respects the mystery of what we do not know, while honoring the rigor of what we can. It does not require certainty to move forward, but demands responsibility in belief.

To abandon the pursuit of truth is to abandon meaning. But to pursue truth humbly, with openness to correction and willingness to revise—this is not weakness. It is integrity.

Final Note

To reject this theory is welcome. But any alternative must meet the same tests: coherence, evidence, reason, and reproducibility. If it does, the torch of truth passes forward.

And we will have served it—not possessed it. For truth belongs to no one, but guides all who seek it in good faith.

References

- Aristotle. *Metaphysics*, Book IV, Part 7.
- Audi, R. (2010). *Epistemology: A Contemporary Introduction to the Theory of Knowledge* (3rd ed.). Routledge.
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